Pitch & Business Plan Submission Platform

Inclusive Workflow — No Citizenship or CIPC Barriers During Selection

---

1. Guiding Principle

Selection is based on the quality of the idea, the founder, the traction and the pitch — not on South African citizenship or CIPC registration status. Formal checks only become relevant when money is about to change hands. This keeps the platform open to the widest possible pool of innovators, including foreign nationals who are legally present in South Africa and early-stage founders who have not yet registered a company.

2. High-Level Process Overview

Stage	Name	Who acts	Key outcome
1	Public Landing Page	Visitor	Understands opportunity & eligibility
2	Multi-step Application	Applicant	Complete submission + files uploaded
3	Admin Review & Shortlisting	Organising team	Shortlist selected on merit
4	Finalist Selection	Organising team	Finalists confirmed
5	Live / Final Event	Finalists + Organisers	Pitches, judging, winners
6	Payment / Funding Condition	Winners + Finance team	CIPC + legal ability to receive funds checked before money moves

Important: There is no automated SA ID or CIPC verification during Stages 1–5. Those checks only appear in Stage 6 (payment).

3. Detailed Stage-by-Stage Description

Stage 1 – Public Landing Page

What it includes / involves:

- Clear explanation of the programme or competition (purpose, who it is for, what participants can gain)

- Key dates: application open/close, shortlist announcement, final event date
- Benefits or prizes on offer
- Eligibility rules written in plain language (age, location, stage of business, etc.)
- Explicit statement that South African citizenship and CIPC registration are **not** required to apply
- Prominent “Apply Now” button that starts the application form

No login is required to view the landing page. The page should feel welcoming and open.

Stage 2 – Multi-Step Application Form

The application is deliberately lightweight. No identity document numbers and no CIPC numbers are requested. The goal is to let founders focus on their idea and traction.

Step 2.1 – Founder Information

- Full name of the primary founder / lead pitcher
- Age or date of birth (only if the programme has an age rule)
- Email address (primary channel for all future communication)
- Mobile number
- Optional: LinkedIn or other professional profile link
- Optional free-text field: “Country of citizenship / legal status in South Africa” (for information only — does not affect eligibility)

Step 2.2 – Venture / Business Information

- Name of the venture or trading name (registered name is not required)
- Short description of what the venture does (1–3 sentences)
- Primary location (city / province / country)
- Current stage: Idea / Pre-revenue / Early revenue / Growth / Scale
- Website and/or social media links (optional)
- Optional: “Is the business already CIPC-registered?” (Yes / No / In process) — informational only, never used for scoring or exclusion

Step 2.3 – Traction & Metrics

- How long the venture has been operating or developing
- Key progress so far (users, revenue, partnerships, pilots, contracts, prototypes, etc.) — free text plus optional structured fields
- Number of people currently involved (founders + team)

Step 2.4 – Pitch Materials (File Uploads)

- Written Executive Summary (Problem, Solution, Market, Execution plan)
- One-minute Elevator Pitch (text field or short video upload)
- Pitch Deck (PDF preferred; recommended size limit 15–20 MB)
- Optional supporting documents (projections, letters of support, product screenshots, etc.)

Files are stored on secure object storage (e.g. Cloudflare R2). Access for reviewers is via temporary signed URLs.

Step 2.5 – Review & Submit

- Applicant sees a full summary of everything entered and uploaded
- Confirms the information is accurate
- Accepts the terms of participation and POPIA privacy consent
- Submits the application

Immediately after submission the applicant receives a confirmation email and can log into a simple dashboard showing status: “Submitted – Under Review”.

Stage 3 – Admin Review & Shortlisting

What the organising team does:

- Log into a secure Admin Dashboard
- View, search and filter all applications
- Open any application to read the executive summary, traction notes and download the pitch deck / video
- Add private scores and internal notes (never visible to the applicant)
- Change status: Submitted → Under Review → Shortlisted → Not selected / Waitlisted
- Select the shortlist (for example Top 20) purely on the quality of the idea, founder and materials No identity or CIPC checks are performed at this stage. Shortlisting is a merit decision only.

Stage 4 – Finalist Selection

From the shortlist the organising team selects the finalists (for example Top 10). Selection criteria typically include innovation, traction, founder quality, market potential and readiness to pitch. Finalists receive a formal notification email with next-step instructions and any event briefing pack.

Still no identity or CIPC verification is required to become a finalist.

Stage 5 – Live / Final Event

What this stage can include:

- Live pitch presentations (timed format, e.g. 3 minutes pitch + 3 minutes Q&A)
- Judges' scoring and/or live audience scoring
- Announcement of winners and prize allocation
- Optional earlier public-voting component if the programme wants a People's Choice element

The platform supports status updates and communication but does not itself have to run the live event logistics.

Stage 6 – Payment / Funding Condition (Only Place Formal Checks Occur)

This is the only stage at which formal checks are introduced. It is an administrative / finance step that happens after winners have been selected and before any money is transferred.

What is required before money is released:

- Proof that the winning venture is registered with CIPC (or that registration has been submitted and is in process)
- Proof that the person or entity receiving the funds is legally able to do so in South Africa (this may include a passport +valid visa/permit, permanent residence permit, or South African ID — whatever the organisation's bank and compliance rules require)
- Any other documents the finance / compliance team normally needs for payment (banking details, tax number if applicable, etc.)

Winners are given a clear and reasonable window (for example 30–60 days after the event) to complete these requirements. The condition is communicated early (in the finalist briefing pack and again when winners are announced) so there are no surprises.

This approach protects the organising organisation while still allowing non-citizens and unregistered early-stage founders to compete fully on merit.

4. Applicant Dashboard & Status Visibility

Every applicant can access a simple personal dashboard (email magic link or light login) that shows:

Status shown to applicant	Meaning	Action needed by applicant?

Submitted – Under Review	Application received; committee is reviewing	No
Shortlisted	Selected for the next stage	No (unless extra materials requested)
Finalist	Selected for the live / final stage	Follow event instructions
Winner / Funded	Selected to receive prize or funding	Yes – complete payment-condition documents
Not Selected	Application will not progress further	No

5. Admin / Organising Team Capabilities

- Full list of applications with filters (status, date, stage, location, etc.)
- Open any application and view all data + download files
- Add private scores and notes
- Change application status
- Export data for offline review or reporting
- Manage basic programme settings (dates, eligibility text, email templates)
- At payment stage: mark that CIPC / legal-ability documents have been received and verified by finance

6. Why This Design Serves "Business and Innovations Funding"

- Does not exclude foreign nationals who are legally in South Africa
- Does not exclude early-stage or first-time founders who have not yet registered a company
- Keeps the application experience fast and modern (NextGen Summit style)
- Still protects the organisation: money only moves after CIPC registration and legal ability to receive funds are confirmed
- Verification cost is near zero during selection because no automated checks run until payment
- Clear communication of the payment condition prevents later disputes

7. Out of Scope for the First Version

- Public voting / People's Choice module (can be added later)
- Live event scoring and real-time leaderboard

- Complex multi-round judging workflows
- Mobile native apps (the web application will be fully responsive)

8. Summary for Project Leadership

The platform invites the widest possible range of founders to submit high-quality pitch applications. Selection is based purely on merit. Formal identity and business-registration checks are reserved for the moment money is about to be paid.

This removes unnecessary barriers while still giving the organising team a clean, compliant way to disburse funds.